



FOR TREE OF LIFE INTERNATIONAL CHURCHES PASTORS

Baptism and Communion in Tree of Life International Churches

FOR PASTORS:

Pray before the Baptismal Service.

Be sure the people are converted.

Prepare certificate to give to each baptismal Candidate after their Baptism.

Baptism must be done by immersion. The person is to be immersed only once in the name of the Father, Son and the Holy Spirit.¹⁹ Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost (Matthew 28:19 "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, **baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost.**")

They are to be dressed in clothing that covers them properly and that will not be transparent when wet.

Towels should be provided to wrap the candidates in immediately after service.

What is the biblical foundation for Baptism?

Jesus' final recorded words to His followers before His ascension to heaven express the importance He placed on Baptism. In Matthew 28:19, Jesus commands His followers, "go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit."

Baptism does not provide salvation for an individual, but rather serves to identify publicly the individual as a follower of Christ. In passages such as Acts 2:41, 8:12, and 10:47–48, the act of Baptism *follows* an individual's decision to trust in Jesus Christ alone for salvation. The New Testament records the Baptisms of adult believers only. In Romans 6:1–11, the apostle Paul describes the immersion of Baptism as a means through which the believer identifies with the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ: Going under the water represents Christ's death—and a believer's death to sin; coming out of the water illustrates His resurrection and the believer's new life in Christ.

Baptism is an act of obedience to Christ that follows an individual's acceptance of salvation by God's grace alone. Baptism isn't a prerequisite for salvation; however, if an inner commitment to trust Christ alone for salvation has been made, then the outward symbol of that commitment—Baptism—should follow, as is modeled throughout the New Testament in the lives of those choosing to follow Christ.

Tree of Life International Churches' Statement on Baptism

The leadership and congregation of Tree of Life International Churches understands Scripture to teach that only professing believers qualify for Baptism.

Scriptural teaching on Baptism may be summarized as follows:

1. Baptism is an act of obedience to the command of Christ, fulfilled by individuals who have submitted themselves to His sovereignty.
2. Baptism symbolizes the spiritual cleansing through divine forgiveness and the newness of life believers experience by virtue of their identification with Christ in His death and resurrection.
3. Baptism provides an opportunity for believers to make a formal profession of their faith before the church.
4. As a biblical rite of initiation into the body of Christ, the Baptism of a believer may be considered as an outward confirmation of their becoming a member of the church.

Although the old covenant practice of infant circumcision is sometimes given as a rationale for infant Baptism, the biblical definition of the functions of circumcision and Baptism shows that those two institutions fulfilled different purposes in their respective covenants. The equation is never made in the Bible between the circumcision of male infants in the old covenant, and the Baptism of born-again believers, much less of infants, in the new covenant. However, Tree of Life International Churches encourages Christian parents to present their children for the ceremony of dedication, whereby God's blessing is formally invoked upon the children, and the parents publicly commit themselves to raise the children in accordance with the teachings of Scripture.

Because the symbolism of Baptism requires a more adult level of cognitive and developmental readiness, the Leadership and Pastors require that children be at least 12 years old to be baptized at Tree of Life International Churches. Proverbs 20:25 issues a significant caution against the danger of making a vow before adequate knowledge, forethought, and reflection have been given. In an effort to prevent young people from making a premature commitment they may not fully understand, this minimum age has been established.

Baptism recognizes and celebrates the redemptive life change that is continually occurring within our church. The Leadership and Pastors encourage new believers and believers who have not yet participated in adult Baptism to be baptized by immersion. The Leadership and Pastors' position is that Baptism by immersion paints the truest picture of dying to sin and arising to Christ and new life.

Does Tree of Life International Churches baptize infants?

If the purpose of Baptism is to publicly identify a believer in Jesus Christ, you may well be asking yourself, "What was the significance of my Baptism as a baby?" In the New Testament, we find parents bringing their children to Jesus. He held them and prayed for them and told His disciples to welcome them. But He did not baptize them, and He did not tell anyone else to baptize them. Baptism is for those who have made a personal decision to trust Christ alone for their salvation.

If you were baptized as a child, it was the intent of your parents that you would one day be a follower of Christ. Your Baptism as an adult can be viewed as the fulfillment of your parents' wishes.

Am I spiritually ready for Baptism?

Once someone professes faith in Jesus Christ for salvation, the Bible says they should proclaim the life change that has occurred—the watching world needs to know. Baptism has always stood as a public testimony for people who have become believers in Christ.

Believers are those who have realized that their sins have separated them from God. They have given up all efforts to reach God through their own good works or religious activity. They have concluded that Jesus Christ's death on the cross for their sins is the only thing that can bridge the gap between them and God. A believer is someone who has decided to trust Christ alone for his or her salvation.

If you have come to this point in your spiritual journey, then you are ready to be baptized. Let the miracle that has happened in you show through the sacrament He ordained for you.

How do I get baptized at Tree of Life International Churches?

If you are ready to get baptized, you will need to complete the following three steps:

STEP ONE: Approach your Branch Pastor.

If you intend to be baptized at Tree of Life International Churches, please ask your Branch Pastor. In some branches most cases you will be asked to complete a Baptism registration form.

STEP TWO: Attend a Baptism Information Meeting

In the weeks leading up to the Baptism weekend, each participant is asked to attend baptismal classes. At these classes, a Tree of Life International Churches pastor, reviews the church's statement on the biblical basis for Baptism and answers any questions you may have. A staff member explains the logistics of check-in and the order of events during the Baptism service. The Baptism team is also available after these meetings to address any further spiritual questions you may have.

STEP THREE: Get Baptized!

Plan to arrive 45 minutes prior to the service. Enter the Main Auditorium and sit in the reserved seating section that has been set aside for you and your guest(s). A service host can guide you to this section. A brief, pre-service meeting provides you with final details of the Baptism service.

Communion/The Lord's Supper

For Pastors: communion service must be held at least once a month. Non alcoholic wine/grape juice is to be used and also bread. The bread should be broken into tiny portions.

ORDER OF LORD'S SUPPER SERVICE

A table is prepared at the front of the auditorium with the communion emblems on it.

When its time to take the communion, The minister moves behind the Lord's Supper table and says: *On the same night in which he was betrayed, took bread: And when he had given thanks, he broke it, and said, Take, eat; this is my body, which is broken for you: This do in remembrance of me. He also reads 1 Corinthians 11:23-32.*

The minister then offers a prayer of thanks to God.

The minister then nods to the deacons who are standing around the table at the front . They come to the table, take a plate of bread, and serve the congregation.

While the bread is being served the organist or pianist plays appropriate

music or the congregation sings a stanza of a hymn that they can do from memory.

When the deacons complete serving they stand at the head of the pew and wait for a nod from the minister. They then return to the front, place their plates on the table, and are seated.

The minister then serves the deacons and returns behind the table.

The minister lifts the bread for the congregation to see, and may say: *"This is the bread which came down from heaven: not as the fathers ate and died; he that eateth this bread shall live forever" (John 6:58).*

The minister then lifts the bread to his mouth and eats it and the congregation follows.

The minister then may say: *"In the same manner also he took the cup, when he had supped, saying, 'This cup is the new testament in my blood: This do you as oft as ye drink it in remembrance of me.' For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do show the Lord's death till he come."*

The minister then offers a second prayer of thanksgiving.

The minister again nods to the deacons, who come to the table, take the cups, and serve the congregation.

The musicians play appropriate music or the congregation sings a stanza of a hymn.

When the deacons have completed serving they stand at the head of the pew and wait for a nod from the minister. They then return to the front, place the trays on the table and are seated.

The minister then serves the deacons and returns behind the table.

The minister then lifts his cup so everyone can see it and may say: *"According to the law . . . all things are cleansed with blood, and apart from the shedding of blood there is no remission" (Heb. 9:22).*

"But if we walk in the light as he is the light, we have fellowship one with another, and the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanses us from all sin" (1 John 1:7).

The minister then lifts the cup to his lips and drinks. The congregation follows.

The minister then places the cup back on the table and may say: *After they had finished the first Supper, they sang a hymn. The musicians and worship team may lead in a song of worship.*

VARIATIONS IN THE LORD'S SUPPER/COMMUNION

The Lord's Supper lends itself to great variety in its observance. In every instance, however, it should be served with reverence and dignity.

What is the biblical foundation for Communion?

Jesus' Last Supper, the Passover meal He shared with His disciples on the night before He was crucified, is the biblical foundation for the Communion/Lord's Supper meal celebrated by Christians all over the world today. With His twelve friends gathered around Him for the traditional Jewish Passover meal, Jesus "took bread, gave thanks and broke it, and gave it to them, saying, 'This is My body, given for you; do this in remembrance of Me.' In the same way, after supper He took the cup, saying, 'This cup is the new covenant in My blood, which is poured out for you'" (Luke 22:19–20).

Who can take Communion/the Lord's Supper?

Communion is "the believer's meal," a sacrament intended for Jesus' followers, by which they acknowledge and remember His work on the cross—the ultimate sacrifice made on our behalf for the forgiveness of the sins of humankind. TOLIC extends an "open" Communion table, meaning the invitation to receive Communion during a TOLIC service is open to any follower of Christ, regardless of membership at TOLIC, denominational affiliation, or spiritual tradition. Anyone who has accepted His forgiveness and surrendered their lives to Him is invited to share the Communion table at Tree of Life International Churches.

Those investigating Christianity who have not yet made a commitment of faith through Jesus Christ are encouraged to simply let the Communion plate pass by, utilizing that portion of the service to pray and invite God's activity into their investigation of faith.

CHILD DEDICATION

Child dedication is a public commitment you make before God, your church, and your family. The dedication service provides you, the parent(s), an opportunity to express publicly your desire to lead and spiritually nurture your child in cooperation with the Holy Spirit, so your child will develop a desire to love God and love others.

What is the biblical purpose and history of a child dedication?

The scriptural root of a child dedication is found in 1 Samuel 1:27–28 (NASB), where a godly woman named Hannah prayed year after year for God to give her a child. He answered her prayer and she gave birth to a son, whom she named Samuel. When Samuel was born, Hannah prayed these words:

"For this boy I prayed, and the Lord has given me my petition which I asked of Him. So I have also dedicated him to the Lord; as long as he lives he is dedicated to the Lord."

In Luke chapter 2 of the New Testament, following the birth of Jesus, Mary and Joseph took the infant Jesus to the temple and dedicated Him.

In both Scripture passages, the parents entrusted their child completely to God.

The writings of Moses found in Deuteronomy 6:5–9 describe God's plan for how a parent should raise up a child:

"Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength."

These commandments that I give you today are to be upon your hearts. Impress them on your children. Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Tie them as symbols on your hands and bind them on your foreheads. Write them on the doorframes of your houses and on your gates."

One key step in marking your desire to nurture your child in the ways of God is to dedicate him or her to God publicly, through a child dedication ceremony.

Do I need to be a Tree of Life International Churches member to have my child dedicated at TOLIC?

We do encourage parents to make sure they are calling TOLIC their home church. Why? In dedicating your child to God, you are stating that you are willing to partner with God *and the church* to raise your child in cooperation with God's intentions. To partner with any church, a parent would be wise to decide if he or she agrees with its beliefs and vision, so they can be all-in in their partnership with the church.

When you choose to become a member at TOLIC, you are stating that you agree with Tree of Life International Churches' beliefs and values, and that you want TOLIC to be your home church. For more information on membership, speak to your Branch Pastor.

To have your child dedicated at TOLIC(Tree of Life International Churches):

- We ask parents to have a personal relationship with Jesus Christ.
- We ask parents to be sure their beliefs line up with Tree of Life International Churches(TOLIC) statement of believes.
- We ask parents to be regular attenders of TOLIC services.
- We ask parents who are living together and who are not married to take steps to acknowledge and surrender to God's plan for their relationship before participating in a child dedication service.

What can I expect during a child dedication ceremony?

During the dedication service, parents express vows before God, their family, and the church, declaring their desire to raise their child in a God-honoring way. Because parents are the key role models for their children, they play a primary role in the dedication service.

Parents will be asked to affirm the following commitments:

- Do you receive this child with gratitude, as God's gift to you and your family?
- Do you commit to each other as parents, creating a stable environment in which your child can mature? Will you make a covenant to strengthen your marriage relationship?
- Do you commit to be parents of personal faith, recognizing your children are more likely to follow God's path by the model they first observe in you?
- Do you commit to lead a faith-filled home that honors God in all your relationships and in the choices you make in spiritually growing your family?
- Do you commit to be parents with patience, recognizing that with your inherent

strengths and weaknesses, your desire to shape your child is a loving act that will require time, prayer, and God in order to produce in your children what He and you hope for?

If you have registered to participate in a scheduled public or group child dedication service, you will be notified of the date and procedure by your Branch Pastor.

Does TOLIC baptize infants?

Scripture provides evidence that Baptism follows an individual's decision to trust Christ alone for salvation (Acts 2:41, 8:12, and 10:47–48). And the New Testament records the baptisms of adult believers only.

In the Bible, we find parents bringing their children to Jesus. He held them, prayed for them, and told us to welcome them. But He did not baptize them and He did not tell anyone else to baptize them. TOLIC believes Baptism is for those who have made a personal decision to trust Christ alone for their salvation, once they have the maturity and ability to understand what that means. As a general rule a believer must be at least 12 years old to be baptized.

Dedication is not a sacrament; nor does it impart grace or salvation to a child. Salvation comes only through faith in Jesus Christ as each person recognizes their sinfulness and receives forgiveness and eternal life through Christ and His work on the cross.

Rather than baptizing infants or children, TOLIC encourages Christian parents to dedicate their children. This is a ceremony in which parents formally call upon God's blessing for their child and publicly commit to raise him or her in accordance with Scripture.

At what age can a child take part in a dedication service?

While Tree of Life International Churches(TOLIC) does not have a set age requirement for child dedication, the average age for a child to be dedicated is four to eight months old, although many parents dedicate children much older than that, often for the following reasons:

- The parent(s) are new believers in Christ and their children were not dedicated when they were infants.
- The parent(s) are having a younger child dedicated and want to have their older child dedicated at the same time.

Can a single parent participate in a child dedication service?

Yes! Child dedication signifies the commitment of parents (including single parents) to do their best to raise their child to be a follower of Christ. Additionally, we highly encourage single parents to dedicate their child as they commit themselves to raise him or her without the presence or partnership of a spouse. The decision to dedicate a child is not dependent upon the beliefs of the ex-spouse; however we encourage single parents to discuss child dedication with their ex-spouse. Ideally, both parents—even if not married—would still commit to the dedication of their child to God. We acknowledge that this is often not possible, and that it takes extra effort for a single parent to raise a child. As a church, Tree of Life International Churches(TOLIC) is committed to supporting single parents in providing a

Christian foundation for their child's upbringing.

Can parent(s) assign godparents?

Although the term "godparent" is not used at TOLIC, we do welcome parents to invite friends and family members committed to supporting them to stand with them during the dedication. The presence of these significant adults symbolizes their commitment to play a supportive role in the child's spiritual development.

MARRIAGE

Step One

Tree of Life International Churches courtship/engaged couples workshop is the best first step to take and then mentoring follows to build godly principles into your relationship. Our desire is to serve and celebrate with you as you plan your wedding day. It is part of Tree of Life International Churches provides pre-marital counseling for all couples planning to get married.

Chapel Availability

The Marriage staff will honor your request to set aside a selected chapel ceremony date and time when you begin the mentoring process.

- The Marriage Ministry will set the date and time aside in order to give you time to participate in premarital counseling and assess your readiness for marriage.
- Blood test , pregnancy and genotype test must be conducted by a reputable doctor that the TOLIC branch will refer you to. This is to determine whether your blood groups are compatible and also for HIV/AIDS screening.
- After you are affirmed by your Branch Pastor, the desired date and time will be released to you and confirmed on the wedding calendar in your name.

Upon placing your name on the wedding calendar, the Wedding Administrator will send you a registration form; this finalizes your wedding date and time.